

Brand Guidelines

A short guide to how we look, sound, and feel. For internal use and collaborators.

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Emotion-led storytelling for brands that need to be believed.

Black Iris Films is a Sydney-based video production company specialising in emotion-led storytelling for finance, fintech, AI, tech, and higher education.

Founded by Titus Maclaren, Black Iris Films sits at the intersection of cinematic craft and strategic clarity. Every project starts from the same principle: people decide emotionally and justify logically. That belief shapes how we write scripts, direct on set, and edit in post.

Our work is characterised by restraint, considered composition, and an instinct for the human moment inside complex subject matter. We work best with clients who care about the difference between content that performs and content that's remembered.

What we believe

- Emotion outperforms information. Across every sector we've studied, emotion-led content reaches the top quartile 2.1x more often than informational content.
- Craft is a competitive advantage. Polish is no longer the point of difference, but strategic clarity expressed through polished craft still is.
- A single strong idea beats five average ones. We'd rather deliver one hero film that earns its keep than five forgettable pieces.
- The best briefs come from the bravest clients.

How we sound

Direct, warm, unhurried. We speak like a senior creative who's seen the inside of 300 edits and can tell you why the third one worked.

Principles

- Plain English, not marketing English. We don't "unlock value" or "elevate narratives." We write things the way we'd say them out loud.
- Specificity over abstraction. "A 90-second founder film for a fintech Series B" beats "bespoke video solutions."
- Confident without being cocky. We have 15 years of work behind us. We don't need to prove it every sentence.
- Warm, not sycophantic. We treat clients like peers, not royalty.
- No em dashes. Use commas, full stops, or colons.
- Australian spelling. Colour, not color. Organisation, not organization.

In practice

USE THIS

"A 90-second brand film your homepage has been missing."

NOT THIS

"Unlock the power of emotional storytelling and elevate your brand's narrative potential."

USE THIS

"We've made films for Qantas, AMP Capital, and a Sydney fintech whose name is in an NDA."

NOT THIS

"Trusted by industry-leading brands, delivering world-class video solutions for over a decade."

The mark

The wordmark pairs the play-ribbon icon with "BLACK IRIS FILMS" set in custom letter-spacing. It's the primary expression of the brand.



BLACK IRIS FILMS

PRIMARY LOGO · ON LIGHT BACKGROUNDS



BLACK IRIS FILMS

REVERSED · ON DARK BACKGROUNDS

Clear space and minimum size

Leave at least the height of the "B" in BLACK as breathing room on all sides. Minimum width 80px on digital, 20mm in print. Below that the icon and wordmark start to lose their balance.

What not to do

AVOID

Stretching, squashing, or rotating the mark. The geometry and proportions are part of the identity.

AVOID

Placing the logo over busy photography without a tint or container.

AVOID

Separating the icon from the wordmark in applications where they should appear together.

AVOID

Recolouring the logo outside navy, white, or reversed on navy.

The palette

Five core colours, plus a rare gold accent. Used with intention, these carry the brand across every surface.



Deep Navy

#29334D

Primary. Text, headers, logo.



Blue Slate

#4B6B8B

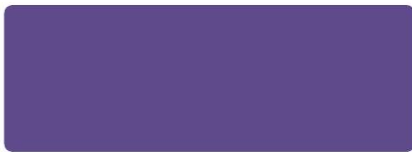
Secondary text, supporting UI.



Emerald Mint

#61B383

CTAs, success states, accents.



Aubergine

#5F4B8B

Tertiary. Cultural, editorial.



Sky Pale

#B7C8D8

Backgrounds, dividers.



Gold (Rare)

#E5B547

Reserved. For standout research or feature moments only.

Shades are allowed

Each colour lives as a range. Brighter and more saturated versions work when context calls for it. Muted versions work when restraint matters. Hex values are anchors, not prisons.

Navy, full range



Mint, full range



How we use colour

Restraint first. A layout with one strong colour feels considered. A layout with five feels confused.

The default system

Navy text on white. Mint reserved for CTAs, accents, and success states. Sky pale for subtle backgrounds, dividers, and muted UI. This covers most work: website, proposals, service pages, email, decks.

DO

Use navy for all body text and headlines by default.

DO

Use mint sparingly as the single accent colour on most surfaces.

DON'T

Stack more than two brand colours in one composition without purpose.

DON'T

Use aubergine on finance and fintech work. It reads too editorial.

Gold: the rare exception

Gold is reserved for the few moments where the work itself signals "this is different." The Theory of Everything study is one example: an original-research piece set apart from the day-to-day service work. Use it when a piece deserves to stand out from the regular brand cadence, not as a routine accent.

ORIGINAL RESEARCH · 2026

The (Social Media) Theory of Everything

Gold signals: this is a one-off, worth paying attention to.

Type system

One family used with discipline. Montserrat carries the entire brand across print, web, and motion.

LIGHT 300 · DISPLAY

Emotion leads. Reason follows.

REGULAR 400 · HEADLINE

Films that earn their place on the homepage.

MEDIUM 500 · SUBHEAD

A considered approach, every time.

REGULAR 400 · BODY

Black Iris Films produces cinematic work for brands that need to be believed. We work with founders, CMOs, and marketing leads who care about the difference between video that performs and video that's remembered.

MEDIUM 500 · LABEL

SINCE 2018 · SYDNEY · AUSTRALIA

Hierarchy rules

- Display (light 300) for hero moments only. One per page.
- Headlines (regular 400) for section openers.
- Subheads (medium 500) for secondary headers.
- Body (regular 400) for long-form text.
- Labels (medium 500, wide tracking, uppercase) for metadata and category lines.
- Avoid bold and black weights. The brand doesn't shout.

Writing style

How we write: whether it's a client email, a website headline, or a sales proposal.

Sentence length

Vary it. A short sentence lands. A longer, more considered sentence lets an idea breathe and gives the reader room to think. Two short. One long. That's a rhythm.

Specificity

Reach for the specific noun over the generic one. "A cinematic founder film" beats "a video." "Finance and fintech" beats "various industries." Specificity is credibility.

Numbers

Use them when they serve the argument. "742 videos studied" is more convincing than "lots of videos." Don't stack numbers for their own sake.

Words we avoid

These words either overpromise, undersell, or sound like every other agency:

- Unlock, elevate, leverage, synergy, solutions, holistic, bespoke, curated, seamless. Agency-speak.
- World-class, industry-leading, cutting-edge. Meaningless superlatives.
- Storytelling experts, visual storytellers, creative partners. Everyone says this.
- Amazing, incredible, awesome. Non-descriptive enthusiasm.

Words we use

- Emotion-led. Our defining descriptor.
- Considered. For craft and restraint.
- Cinematic. For scale and mood.
- Strategic. For the thinking behind the shot.
- Warmth, craft, idea. Recurring nouns.

In use

How the system comes together across different surfaces.

Website, decks, and proposals

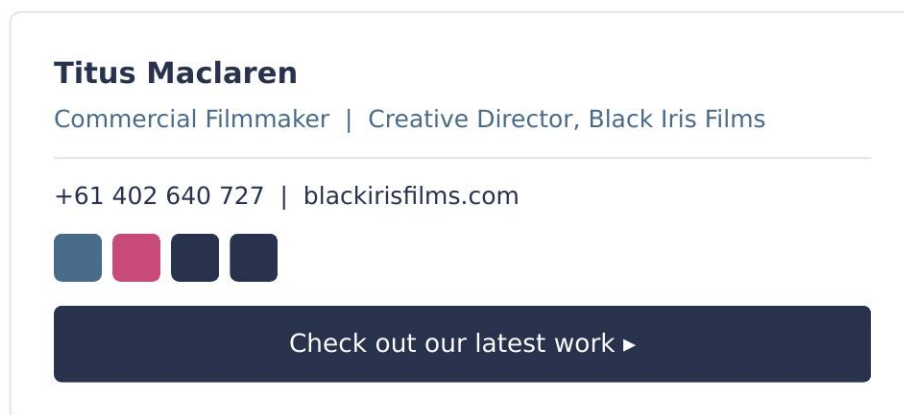
White and off-white backgrounds. Navy text and headers. Mint only on primary CTAs. Generous whitespace. Montserrat throughout. Gold does not appear here.

Stand-out pieces (rare)

When a piece of work genuinely warrants it, original research, a signature case study, or a feature-level moment, gold is allowed on a dark navy background. These should be exceptions, not the norm. If you're reaching for gold more than once or twice a year, it's losing its meaning.

Email signature

A structured block, not a plaintext line. Name in navy, title in slate, social icons in brand colours, primary CTA styled as a button.



Social media

Lean into restraint. Most agencies over-design social content. Ours should feel editorial by comparison: lots of white, considered crops, quiet type. Let the work do the talking.

This document will evolve. If something here stops serving the brand, change it. Guidelines exist to make decisions faster, not to replace judgement.

END OF DOCUMENT · V1.0 · APRIL 2026